

Cautions Do not take the essential oil internally. Do not use sweet gale internally in pregnancy or while breastfeeding. The essential oil is thought to be toxic.

Myroxylon pereiara
syn. *M. balsamum* var. *pereiara*
(Fabaceae)

Peruvian Balsam

Description Evergreen tree growing to 115 ft (35 m). Has grey bark, compound leaves dotted with oil glands, white pea-like flowers, and yellow seed pods.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Central America, Peruvian balsam grows wild in tropical forests. It is cultivated in Central and South America and India. Oleoresin (balsam) is taken from cuts in the bark.

Part Used Oleoresin.

Constituents The oleoresin contains 50–65% volatile oil (mainly benzyl benzoate and benzyl cinnamate) and resins.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Peruvian balsam is strongly antiseptic and stimulates repair of damaged tissue. It is most commonly taken internally as an expectorant and antimucus remedy to treat bronchitis, emphysema, and bronchial asthma. It may also be taken to treat sore throats and diarrhea, and applied topically to skin disorders.

Related Species The balsam from similar species was used by the Inca to relieve fevers and colds.

Caution Peruvian balsam may cause allergic skin reactions.

Myrtus communis (Myrtaceae)

Myrtle

Description Evergreen shrub growing to a height of 10 ft (3 m). Has dark green leaves, white flowers, and purple-black berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Myrtle is native to the Mediterranean region and it is cultivated for its essential oil. The leaves are gathered in spring.

Parts Used Leaves, essential oil.

Constituents Myrtle contains tannins, flavonoids, and a volatile oil (mainly alpha-pinene, cineole, and myrtenol).

History & Folklore In ancient Greece, myrtle was dedicated to Aphrodite, who was the goddess of love, and brides bedecked themselves with myrtle leaves. A liqueur is made from the berries.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Myrtle leaves are astringent, tonic, and antiseptic. An infusion of the leaves can be used externally to clean and heal wounds and ulcers, or internally to remedy disorders

of the digestive and urinary systems. The essential oil is strongly antiseptic and anti-mucus, and in Spain is used to treat bronchial and lung infections.

Caution Do not take the essential oil internally except with professional advice.



Myrtle was described by the Greek physician Dioscorides as "a friend to the stomach."

Nasturtium officinale (Cruciferae)

Watercress

Description Creeping perennial growing to 2 ft (60 cm), with compound leaves, spikes of white 4-petaled flowers, and small sickle-shaped pods.

Habitat & Cultivation Found in temperate regions throughout the world, watercress thrives alongside or in fresh running water. While commonly found in the wild, it is also widely cultivated as a salad herb. Watercress is best gathered before it flowers in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Watercress contains isothiocyanates and is rich in vitamins A, B₁, B₂, C, and E, and minerals (especially iodine, iron, and phosphorus). Allyl isothiocyanate has broad-spectrum antibiotic activity. Research in the 1960s suggested that watercress might have antitumor activity.

History & Folklore Watercress has long been valued as a food and medicinal plant. Xenophon, a Greek general in the 5th century BCE, attributed other virtues to it, recommending the Persians to feed it to their children to build up their strength.

In European folk medicine, watercress has primarily been considered a "blood-cleanser," and was used in former times as a spring tonic.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Watercress provides excellent, easily digested nutrition. Its high mineral and vitamin C content makes it particularly suited for chronic ill health and convalescence. It is thought to stimulate appetite, ease indigestion, and counter mucus. A detoxifying herb and food, watercress cleanses the liver, blood, kidneys, and lungs.

Nepeta cataria (Lamiaceae)

Catnip

Description Downy, aromatic perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has heart-shaped, gray-green leaves and whorls of white flowers with purple spots.

Habitat & Cultivation Catnip is native to Europe and naturalized in North America. It grows in dry wayside places and in mountainous regions up to altitudes of 5,000 ft (1,500 m). Catnip is gathered when in flower in summer and autumn.

Parts Used Aerial parts.



Catnip helps to lower fever by strongly encouraging sweating.

Constituents Catnip contains iridoids, tannins, and volatile oil (mainly comprising alpha- and beta-nepetalactone, citronellol, and geraniol).

History & Folklore Pechey's *Compleat Herbal* (1694) describes catnip: "'Tis hot and dry. 'Tis chiefly used for obstructions of the womb, for barrenness, and to hasten delivery, and to help